

HCL Beanstalk AQ265 Media Center

The infotainer

Encased in a cubic chassis, the AQ265 runs the Media Center Edition of Windows XP, and offers a complete home entertainment solution in a single package.

Powered by Intel P4 2.6 GHz, 256 MB DDRAM, 845GE, 128 MB nVidia GeForce 5200 AGP card, combo drive, 15-inch LCD screen, Altec Lansing ATP3 2.1 speakers and an 80 GB hard drive that's enough to store approximately 80,000 minutes of music in 128 KB lame MP3 format, or approximately 120 hours of video in MPEG-1 format. Armed with an onboard MPEG2 encoder and an FM tuner, the internal Hauppauge TV-tuner card provides media functionality.

Other package contents include gamepad, internal fax modem, etc. It also bundles along Windows XP Media Center Edition and Norton AntiVirus.

On the performance front, it put forth its best foot in some areas, but did not do well in the others. For example, the poor SiSoft Sandra disk index indicated a poor hard drive system. This was also reflected in the Content Creation and Business Winstone tests that logged 18 and 17.3 respectively. Collectively, it implies that it's an average PC for business users.

However, on the gaming front, it was an entirely different story. It pitched in 259 fps at 640 x 480 for *Quake III* and 129.82 (flyby) at the same resolution in the case of *UT 2003*—these indicate that it does well in performance. It came out with brilliant scores in the video-encoding test too, thus showing itself worthy

of its job. As far as the actual recording format is concerned, you have four options—fair, good, better, or best.

The big, bold font used in the Media Center interface lets you read text from as far as 10 feet from the screen. Use the neat and clean remote control interface to navigate throughout the software without the slightest bit of strain. And you'll hardly exert yourself configuring it.

Features-wise, it has time-shifting TV, advertisement-skipping, scheduled recording and instant replay of 10 seconds. While scheduling, recordings may overlap then you can manually resolve this conflict, or set the software to do so automatically.

The Media Center software also helps you link a series of episodes. It provides you options to keep the recorded file until space needed. It also lets you specify whether you wish to keep the recorded file for one week or until you have watched the recording. Thus, it lets you manage your recorded files and do away with recordings that are not necessary. Management functionality is provided for music as well as image files.

If you find the price tag to be on the higher side, opt for a slightly low-end model. Featuring a 17-inch flat CRT display, 40 GB hard drive and a P4 2.5 GHz processor, it's priced at Rs 50,000.

In all, the Beanstalk AQ265 has all the components of basic capture software, along with advanced features such as Instant Replay, Play/Pause Live TV, etc, which makes TV-viewing more thrilling.



Capturing video, listening to FM or music, is all just a mouse click away, thanks to the easy to use software interface

Price: Rs 74,999

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This media center PC enables you to watch TV as well as tune in to your favorite FM channel all with a click on the remote

